

OPENOFFICE CALC

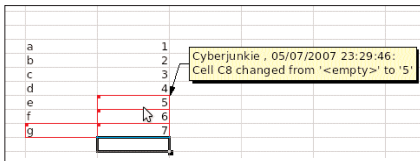


Illustrations Harsho Mohan Chatteraj

Word processing software for Linux is in fair abundance; not so for spreadsheet applications. OpenOffice Calc is the heavyweight in this category, and is the preferred Linux equivalent of Microsoft's Excel.

Tracking Changes

If you changed a cell's value, and made twenty more changes to different cells before deciding that you wanted the first cell's original value, you'd have undo all twenty steps to get it back. A better option is to track all the changes made to your spreadsheet.



Detailed changes made to any cell can easily be viewed

Go to Edit > Changes > Record. From now on, all changes made to cells will be tracked. Modified cells will be shown with a red border; move the mouse over a cell to see its previous value.

Customising The Interface For A Single Spreadsheet

Calc lets you customise its layout for a single spreadsheet only, leaving the default for other sheets.

Select Tools > Customize. Choose the toolbars you want to disable or change the order of. You can do the same for all the toolbars in OpenOffice Calc. Now to bind the customisations to only the file you are working on, click Save in the drop-down menu, and choose the file. Click OK to save.



Macros For Events

Macros in OpenOffice can be bound to events as well, so you can have a macro to run the moment you open a file, for example.

Click on Tools > Customize. Then click on the Events tab. Choose the event that you want to bind the macro to. Click the Macro button. From the library, select the macro you want and click OK.



Macros can be set to be triggered by events in Calc

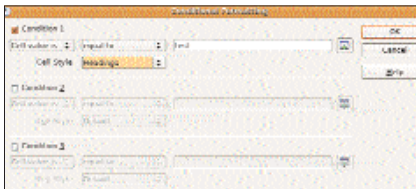


Styles And Conditional Formatting

Conditional Formatting automatically formats cells matching criteria you set, as you might know.

First create some unique styles if you don't like the ones provided by OpenOffice. Select Format > Styles and Formatting. Right-click in the window and click New. Enter a name for the style and use the tabs Fonts, Font Effects, Borders, etc.—to create your own style. You can use this style on any cell from the toolbars.

Now to set up conditional formatting. Select Format >



Cells can be formatted automatically according to set criteria

Conditional Formatting. Set the values for the conditions—equal to, less than, and so on—and select the Cell Style using the drop-down menu. Your custom style will be present as well. When done, click OK. All the cells matching the criteria should then appear in the style you created.



The Function Wizard

Some of us might have knowledge of a fair number of functions for Calc, but not all. The entire list of functions can be viewed using the Function Wizard. Select Insert > Function or press [Ctrl] + [F2]. Choose the Category of functions in the drop-down menu and click on a particular function. A brief description of the function is displayed.

To implement the function, click Next. You will be asked to enter the information needed for the function. Instead of entering values, you can get



The Function Wizard is an easy way to access and implement the huge database of functions

Calc to pick up data from the spreadsheet by clicking on a particular cell. Click OK when all the parameters are filled in. To have the function list available at all times as a sidebar, select Insert > Function List. Click on Fx in the sidebar to use a particular function and manually enter the values needed.



Comparing Spreadsheets

When a single spreadsheet is passed around among people, there are some changes and feedback that may be added to the spreadsheet. Select Edit > Compare Document. Browse to the location of the other spreadsheet and click Open. You'll get a detailed list of differences, with the option to reject or accept changes. The necessary changes are then made to the spreadsheet you were initially working on.



Set Print Ranges

Cells not in the print range in OpenOffice Calc are regions that won't be printed or exported—this is useful if you've used a few cells to take notes or just don't want them to print. To add regions to a print range, highlight a selection of cells. Then go to Format > Print Ranges > Define. You can further add and remove cells in the same manner by clicking on Add and Remove from the same menu.



Tracking Versions

Calc lets you save multiple versions of your spreadsheet and switch to any one when you need to. To save the state of the spreadsheet, go to File > Version > Save New Version and enter a summary for the version. Multiple versions can be saved in the same manner. To access any of the versions, click on a version and click Open. A new read-only spreadsheet with the saved state will load.



Automatic Value Highlighting

While entering huge amounts of data including headings and numbers, Calc can help reduce the confusion by automatically assigning colours to numerical values. Select View > Value Highlighting or press [Ctrl] + [F8]. All numerical values will automatically appear in different colours. ☑